

Disarmament and International Security Committee
Study Guide



**Agenda: Deliberating on the Operation of Lethal
Autonomous Weapons System**

Global School of Science Model United Nations
2026



Message from the Board of Dais

Dear Delegates,

Warmest Greetings!

We are honored to be serving on the Board of Dais of the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, the Disarmament and International Security Committee, of GSS MUN 2026. The agenda that the committee shall deliberate over is “Deliberating on the operation of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems.”

Over the course of the three days, we expect detailed research and accurate facts and figures to be presented in committee alongside the mandatory skill of diplomacy, passion to learn and of making mistakes without fear. I'd like to remind everyone that this conference can yield positive results only if the delegates work with passion and zeal.

While you take on the role of officials representing whole nations, I'd like you to empathize with the individuals whose plights we will be discussing. Remind yourself always that the cases and numbers in your research are real individuals, and real cases of humanity forgone. Do not take the committee and the issue on hand lightly, and feel free to take this as a suggestion, direction, or a warning.

We pledge to be at your disposal as on-deck pedagogues for any and all queries you might have in regards to the conference, the agenda and the committee. Feel free to contact us on any social media platforms or through email. We wish you all the best!

Best Regards,

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Vice Chairperson, DISEC

*The list of references has been omitted in this document, and instead all resources listed in the footnotes.
Note that this is not an original document, but a compilation of resources for your perusal.*

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Introduction to the UNGA

Established in 1945 under the Charter of the United Nations, the General Assembly occupies a central position as the chief deliberative, policymaking and representative organ of the United Nations. Comprised of all 193 Members of the United Nations, it provides a unique forum for multilateral discussion of the full spectrum of international issues covered by the Charter. It also plays a central role in the process of standard-setting and the codification of international law.

According to the Charter of the United Nations, the General Assembly may:

- Consider and approve the United Nations budget and establish the financial assessments of Member States
- Elect the non-permanent members of the Security Council and the members of other United Nations councils and organs and, on the recommendation of the Security Council, appoint the Secretary-General
- Consider and make recommendations on the general principles of cooperation for maintaining international peace and security, including disarmament
- Discuss any question relating to international peace and security and, except where a dispute or situation is currently being discussed by the Security Council, make recommendations on it ● Discuss, with the same exception, and make recommendations on any questions within the scope of the Charter or affecting the powers and functions of any organ of the United Nations ● Initiate studies and make recommendations to promote international political cooperation, the development and codification of international law, the realization of human rights and fundamental freedoms, and international collaboration in the economic, social, humanitarian, cultural, educational and health fields
- Make recommendations for the peaceful settlement of any situation that might impair friendly relations among countries
- Consider reports from the Security Council and other United Nations organs

The Assembly may also take action in cases of a threat to the peace, breach of peace or act of aggression, when the Security Council has failed to act owing to the negative vote of a permanent member. In such instances, according to its “Uniting for peace” resolution of 3 November 1950, the Assembly may consider the matter immediately and recommend to its Members collective measures to maintain or restore international peace and security.¹

¹ <https://www.un.org/en/ga/about/background.shtml>

Introduction to DISEC

The First Committee deals with disarmament, global challenges and threats to peace that affect the international community and seeks out solutions to the challenges in the international security regime.

It considers all disarmament and international security matters within the scope of the Charter or relating to the powers and functions of any other organ of the United Nations; the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, as well as principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments; promotion of cooperative arrangements and measures aimed at strengthening stability through lower levels of armaments.

During the 48th session of the Assembly, in 1993, the item entitled “Rationalization of the work and reform of the agenda of the First Committee” was included in the agenda of the Assembly. Thereafter, the Assembly has focused on improving the effectiveness of the methods of work of the First Committee.²

Resolution 48/87 of 16 December 1993³ specifies:

“2. Decides also, in relation to the restructuring and reorganization of the annual agenda of the First Committee, to adopt, in order to promote more detailed and focused discussions, a thematic approach whereby items presented by Member States are clustered in broad topic areas, such as: A. Nuclear weapons;

- B. Other weapons of mass destruction;
- C. Conventional weapons;
- D. Regional disarmament and security;
- E. Confidence-building measures, including transparency in armaments;
- F. Outer space (disarmament aspects);
- G. Disarmament machinery;
- H. Other disarmament measures;
- I. International security;
- J. Related matters of disarmament and international security;”

²<https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/>

³<https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/48/87>

Introduction to the Agenda

The Office for Disarmament Affairs offers, “At present, no commonly agreed definition of Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems (LAWS) exists.”⁴

The Office elaborates, “The most common types of weapons with autonomous functions are defensive systems. This includes systems such as antivehicle and antipersonnel mines, which, once activated, operate autonomously based on trigger mechanisms.

Newer systems employing increasingly sophisticated technology include missile defense systems and sentry systems, which can autonomously detect and engage targets and issue warnings. Other examples include loitering munition (also known as suicide, kamikaze or exploding drone) which contain a built-in warhead (munition) and wait (loiter) around a predefined area until a target is located by an operator on the ground or by automated sensors onboard, and then attacks the target. These systems first emerged in the 1980s; however, their systems functionalities have since become increasingly sophisticated, allowing for, among other things, longer ranges, heavier payloads and the potential incorporation of artificial intelligence (AI) technologies.

Land and sea vehicles with autonomous capabilities are also increasingly being developed. Those systems are primarily designed for reconnaissance and information gathering but may possess offensive capabilities.”

The debate around LAWS exist due to the unpredictability of the threat they possess, and the causes exhibit themselves in the draft that passes without a vote in the 78th session⁵ of the first committee, which reads:

“*Recognizing* the rapid development of new and emerging technologies, and recognizing further that they hold great promise for the advancement of human welfare and could, inter alia, help to better protect civilians in conflict in certain circumstances,

Mindful of the serious challenges and concerns that new technological applications in the military domain, including those related to artificial intelligence and autonomy in weapons systems, also raise from humanitarian, legal, security, technological and ethical perspectives,

Concerned about the possible negative consequences and impact of autonomous weapon systems on global security and regional and international stability, including the risk of an emerging arms race, lowering the threshold for conflict and proliferation, including to non-State actors,”

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<https://disarmament.unoda.org/the-convention-on-certain-conventional-weapons/background-on-laws-in-the-ccw/>⁵
<https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/78/241>

Introduction to the CCW

The Convention on Prohibitions or Restrictions on the Use of Certain Conventional Weapons Which May Be Deemed to Be Excessively Injurious or to Have Indiscriminate Effects as amended on 21 December 2001, usually referred to as the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), is a key international humanitarian law instrument. Its purpose is to ban or restrict the use of specific types of weapons that are considered to cause unnecessary or unjustifiable suffering to combatants or to affect civilians indiscriminately.⁶

Timeline of LAWS in the CCW⁷

2013	Following a report by UN Special Rapporteur on extrajudicial, summary or arbitrary executions Christof Heyns, the CCW Meeting of High Contracting Parties (HCP) decided that the Chairperson will convene in 2014 an Informal Meeting of Experts to discuss the questions related to emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS).
2014	The first Informal Meeting of Experts is held in accordance with the decision of the 2013 CCW Meeting of HCPs.
2015	The Second Informal Meeting of Experts is held.

2016	The third Informal Meeting of Experts is held.
2016	At the CCW Fifth Review Conference, HCPs decide to establish an open-ended Group of Governmental Experts on Emerging Technologies in the Area of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems. Mandate: to build on the work of the previous meetings of experts and to explore and agree on possible recommendations on options related to emerging technologies in the area of LAWS, in the context of the objectives and purposes of the Convention.
2017	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for five days under the mandate agreed upon at the Fifth Review Conference.
2018	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for 10 days and affirms 10 guiding principles.

⁶<https://disarmament.unoda.org/the-convention-on-certain-conventional-weapons/>

⁷<https://disarmament.unoda.org/timeline-of-laws-in-the-ccw/>

2019	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for seven days and identifies one additional guiding principle. The Group recommends the CCW HCPs endorse the 11 guiding principles at the annual Meeting.
2019	The CCW Meeting of the High Contracting Parties adopts 11 guiding principles per the recommendation of the 2019 GGE.
2021	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for 20 days and prepares the work of the CCW Sixth Review Conference, held in December 2021. No substantive report is adopted.
2021	At the Sixth Review Conference, CCW HCPs, inter alia, affirm that international humanitarian law continues to apply fully to all weapons systems, including the potential development and use of LAWS, and that a lethal autonomous weapon must not be used if it is of a nature to cause superfluous injury or unnecessary suffering, or if it is inherently indiscriminate, or is otherwise incapable of being used in accordance with international humanitarian law. The Review Conference decides on the new mandate to: “consider proposals and elaborate, by consensus, possible measures (...)”.
2022	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for ten days and decides to continue its work by intensifying the consideration of proposals.

2023	The Group of Governmental Experts meets for 10 days and, inter alia, converges on the notion that weapons systems based on emerging technologies in the area of LAWS must not be used if they are incapable of being used in compliance with IHL.
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Documents Crucial to the Debate

The importance of these documents arise from their impact in the arena of LAWS and the discussions and policies around them, but also offer insight into the opinions of states and blocs.

(Note: Use these documents to understand your country's policies towards LAWS and establish your principles accordingly)

1. Resolution adopted by the General Assembly on 22 December 2023⁸
2. Report of the Secretary-General⁹
3. Convention on Prohibitions or Restrictions on the Use of Certain Conventional Weapons Which May Be Deemed to Be Excessively Injurious or to Have Indiscriminate Effects¹⁰

Resources (Offered by the ODA)¹¹

Title	Publishing entity	Year	Link
Report of the Special Rapporteur on extrajudicial summary or arbitrary executions	United Nations Human Rights Council	2013	https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/755741?ln=en

Human rights implications of new and emerging technologies in the military domain (A/HRC/51/L.25)

United Nations Human Rights Council Resolution

2022

<https://daccess-ods.un.org/tmp/8317592.14401245.html>

Artificial intelligence and machine learning in armed conflict: A human-centred approach

Legal Reviews of New Weapons

⁸<https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/78/241>

⁹<https://docs.un.org/en/A/79/88>

¹⁰<https://docs.un.org/en/A/C.1/78/L.44>

ICRC 2020 <https://international-review.icrc.org/sites/default/files/reviews-pdf/2021-03/ai-and-machine-learning-in-armed-conflict-a-human-centred-approach-913.pdf>

ICRC 2021 <https://www.icrc.org/en/document/new-w>

¹¹ <https://disarmament.unoda.org/resources-2/>

Position on Autonomous Weapons Systems	ICRC	2021	https://www.icrc.org/en/document/icrc-position-autonomous-weapon-systems
A Comparative Analysis of the Definitions of Autonomous Weapons Systems	UNODA	2021	https://documents.unoda.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/10/20210721-Autonomous-Weapon-Systems-Definitions-TO-SHARE.pdf
What you need to know about autonomous weapons	ICRC	2022	https://www.icrc.org/en/document/what-you-need-know-about-autonomous-weapons
Towards Responsible AI in Defence: A Mapping and Comparative Analysis of AI Principles Adopted by States	UNIDIR	2023	https://www.unidir.org/sites/default/files/2023-02/Brief-ResponsibleAI-Final.pdf
Proposals Related to Emerging Technologies in the Area of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems: A Resource Paper	UNIDIR	2023	https://www.unidir.org/sites/default/files/2023-05/UNIDIR-Proposals_Emerging_Technologies_Lethal_Autonomous_Weapons_Systems_2023.pdf
Table-Top Exercises on the Human Element and Autonomous Weapons System, 2021	UNIDIR	2021	https://www.unidir.org/publication/table-top-exercises-human-element-and-autonomous-weapons-system
Confidence-Building Measures for Artificial Intelligence	UNIDIR	2022	https://www.unidir.org/sites/default/files/2022-12/Confidence-Building_Final.pdf

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Human-Machine Interfaces in Autonomous Weapons Systems	UNIDIR	2022	https://www.unidir.org/sites/default/files/2022-07/UNIDIR_Human-Machine%20Interfaces.pdf
Known Unknowns: Data Issues and Military Autonomous Systems	UNIDIR	2021	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/2021-05/Holland_KnownUnknowns_20210517_0.pdf
The Black Box, Unlocked: Predictability and Understandability in Military AI	UNIDIR	2020	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/2020-09/BlackBoxUnlocked.pdf

Modernizing Arms Control: Exploring Responses to the Use of AI in Military Decision-Making	UNIDIR	2020	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/2020-09/Modernizing%20Arms%20Control%20-%20Final.pdf
Swarm Robotics: Technical and Operational Overview of the Next Generation of Autonomous Systems	UNIDIR	2020	https://www.unidir.org/sites/default/files/2020-04/UNIDIR%20Swarm%20Robotics%20-%202020.pdf
The Human Element in Decisions About the Use of Force	UNIDIR	2020	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/2020-03/UNIDIR_Iceberg_SinglePages_web.pdf
The Role of Data in Algorithmic Decision-Making	UNIDIR	2019	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/publication/pdfs/the-role-of-data-in-algorithmic-decision-making-en-815.pdf
Algorithmic Bias and the Weaponization of Increasingly Autonomous Technologies	UNIDIR	2018	https://unidir.org/sites/default/files/publication/pdfs/algorithmic-bias-and-the-weaponization-of-increasingly-autonomous-tec

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Resources from Independent Institutions, or Collaborative Researches

Title	Publishing entity	Year	Link
Completely outside human control?	Article 36	2023	https://article36.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Completely-outside-human-control.pdf
Laws for LAWS: Towards a treaty to regulate lethal autonomous weapons	Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung	2023	https://library.fes.de/pdf-files/international/20013.pdf
An Agenda for Action	Human Rights Watch	2022	https://www.hrw.org/report/2022/11/10/agenda-action/alternative-processes-negotiating-killer-robots-treaty
Negotiating a Treaty on Autonomous Weapons Systems – The Way Forward	Stop Killer Robots Campaign	2022	https://www.stopkillerrobots.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/Stop-Killer-Robots-Negotiating-a-Treaty-on-Autonomous-Weapons-Systems-The-Way-Forward.pdf

Principles for the Combat Employment of Weapon Systems with Autonomous Functionalities	Center for a New American Security	2021	https://www.cnas.org/publications/reports/proposed-dod-principles-for-the-combat-employment-of-weapon-systems-with-autonomous-functionalities
Code of Conduct on Artificial Intelligence in Military Systems	Centre for Humanitarian Dialogue	2021	https://www.hdcentre.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/08/AI-Code-of-Conduct.pdf
New Weapons, Proven Precedent	Human Rights Watch	2020	https://www.hrw.org/report/2020/10/20/new-weapons-proven-precedent/elements-and-models-treaty-killer-robots

AI, Emerging Technology and LAWS: Security, Moral, and Ethical Perspectives in Asia	Nonviolence International Southeast Asia	2020	https://www.stopkillerrobots.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/NISEA-AI-Emerging-Tech-and-LAWS-Perspectives-in-Asia.pdf
The Militarization of Artificial Intelligence	Stanley Center for Peace and Security, UNODA & Stimson Center	2019	https://front.un-arm.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/06/Stanley-Stimson-UNODA-2020-TheMilitarization-ArtificialIntelligence.pdf

QARMA_s

1. Can a standard definition for LAWS be established?
2. How can the development, deployment, and utilization of LAWS be monitored, verified, and made transparent?
3. On whom, does the question of accountability fall in case of the malfunction of LAWS mechanisms?
4. Do the current documents and resolutions require amendments?